CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 2 - Code Signing Working Group

Last updated: 2026-10-19

About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. It uses several AI models from competing labs, running on different platforms. One model gathers the current claims on a topic, a different one checks each claim against its source, and disagreements are kept, not smoothed over. The aim is an even-handed account that no outside party has shaped. AI makes mistakes, and so does the system built around it. We find and fix some in every cycle, so the methods keep changing and the content should improve over time. Updates come at least quarterly, sooner if something major happens.

The Code Signing Working Group writes the rules for the certificates that sign software. It is a smaller and slower group than the one governing web server certificates. Section 1 covers the published requirements and the ballots that produced them. Section 2 covers the ballots now open, and Section 3 covers the one software platform that sits in the group as a certificate consumer.

A warning about sourcing belongs at the front of this part. The Forum publishes two pages for this group, one listing ballots and one listing requirements, and they still disagree about which version is current. The ballots page presents version 3.8 from August 2024 as the latest release [1]. The requirements page correctly shows version 3.11.0 [2]. Anyone reading only the first page would be wrong by three releases.

1. Published Requirements and the Ballots Behind Them

Every numbered version of the Code Signing Baseline Requirements comes from a ballot. The version history is the record of what the group has actually agreed, as distinct from what it has debated.

Recent Developments

The current version is 3.11.0, adopted through Ballot CSC-32 [2]. Its intellectual property review ended without objections on 16 June 2026 [3]. It makes a Reserved Policy OID mandatory in subscriber certificates [2]. That rule has been in force since its effective date of 15 September 2026 [2].

Version 3.10 came from Ballot CSC-31, titled Maximum Validity Reduction, which passed on 17 November 2025 [4] [2]. The group is following the same direction as the server certificate rules, shortening the time a signing certificate stays valid. Version 3.9 came from Ballot CSC-26 and covered timestamping private key protection [2]. Version 3.8 came from Ballot CSC-25 and folded the Extended Validation Code Signing Guidelines into the Baseline Requirements [2].

Current State

The Forum's software repository does not match its website either. Its releases page lists version 3.8 as the newest release, and versions 3.9, 3.10 and 3.11 were never tagged there [5]. The requirements page is the record to read for the version in force [2].

The group has twice rejected wholesale alignment with the server certificate rules. Ballot CSC-030, the June 2025 alignment ballot, failed [6]. Ballot CSC-029, the March 2025 alignment ballot, failed before it [7]. Two failures on the same kind of proposal say something about this group's appetite for importing another group's changes as a block.

2. Ballots Now Open

Two ballots are open, one moving quickly and one that has not moved since June. Neither has yet changed the published text.

Recent Developments

Ballot CSC-034 is in its voting period. It clarifies how the organization name field is used when the certificate subject is a natural person [8]. Dimitris Zacharopoulos of HARICA proposed it on 6 October, with endorsements from eMudhra and Sectigo [8]. Its draft first appeared as a pull request on 24 September [9].

The ballot moved through its stages on schedule. Discussion ran from 6 October to 14 October, and voting runs from 14 October to 21 October at 17:00 UTC [10]. By 16 October three members had voted yes, namely HARICA, eMudhra and Certum, and no one had voted against or abstained [10]. Sectigo, an endorser, had not yet voted in the public thread [10].

One drafting slip is visible in the text. The ballot's purpose section cites version 3.11 of the requirements, while its motion says the changes are based on version 3.10 [8]. The Forum's ballots page has not yet listed CSC-034 at any stage [1].

Current State

Ballot CSC-033 is a third attempt at alignment with the server certificate rules, and it is stalled. DigiCert proposed it with endorsements from HARICA and Sectigo, and its discussion period opened on 26 May 2026 [11]. It would import three server certificate rules with future dates [11]. These are a recommendation to lint certificates before issuance, a requirement to check for weak private keys, and a requirement to refresh status responses on a set schedule [11].

Discussion was due to end no earlier than 2 June, and no vote has been called since [11]. The last public replies, on 8 June, raised a cross-reference typo, a broken link and syntax fixes [12]. No result or withdrawal has been posted, and its pull request has not changed since 26 May [12].

The group's earlier minutes point the same way as CSC-033. In May the group agreed on 15 March 2027 as the effective date for both a linting requirement and weekly weak-key checks [13]. A ballot raising the minimum RSA key size for root and subordinate certificates was also under way then [13]. It mirrors a change the S/MIME group has already published, which Part 3 describes.

Unresolved Conflicts

The record of post-quantum signing in this group is thin. A draft to add ML-DSA to the code signing rules was closed without being merged on 29 June 2026, and no replacement has been opened [14]. The group's web pages and its repository both show no post-quantum ballot at any stage [1] [14]. A new pull request or a ballot announcement would show that the question has returned.

3. The Certificate Consumer

A certificate consumer is the software maker whose platform decides which code signing certificates to trust. In this group that is Microsoft alone.

Current State

The group has 14 certificate authorities as members, with Microsoft as the only certificate consumer [15]. The chair is Martijn Katerbarg of Sectigo, who stays in the role for the term from 1 December [15] [16]. Dean Coclin of DigiCert was confirmed as the incoming vice-chair in October [16]. Part 6 covers the wider Forum elections.

Microsoft's rules sit in its Trusted Root Program repository, which it names as the official source over its older documentation pages [17]. The newest change there is from 28 August 2026 and concerned its post-quantum pilot, and nothing has been added since [18]. For roots submitted from 1 July 2026, code signing must have its own root, separate from server and email roots [19]. Such a root may also cover client authentication and time stamping [19].

The older documentation page still carries the specific code signing rules [20]. New code signing and time-stamping roots must use 4096-bit RSA keys, and elliptic curve keys are not accepted for code signing [20]. Extended Validation code signing stopped being recognised in February 2024 [20]. An authority that issues code signing certificates must also run a time-stamping service [20].

The Extended Validation change shows up for developers. An Extended Validation certificate no longer bypasses Windows reputation checks, so both kinds of certificate must build reputation through downloads [21]. Store packages are re-signed by Microsoft and get full reputation, while ordinary installers need a signature chaining to a program member [21]. Microsoft recommends its Artifact Signing service, formerly Trusted Signing, for software outside the Store [21]. It is open to organisations in the United States, Canada, the European Union and the United Kingdom, and to individuals in the United States and Canada [21].

Signing rules for other platforms, such as Java and Adobe, were not checked for this edition. Their absence here is a gap, not a finding.

Sources

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